Beauty: When the Other Dancer is the Self

By Alice Walker

NOTE: Speaker is an African-American woman

It is a bright summer day in 1947. My father, a fat, funny man with beautiful eyes, is trying to decide which of his eight children he will take with him to the county fair. I am two-and-a-half years old. I want to go everywhere my daddy goes. I am excited at the prospect of riding in a car. Someone has told me fairs are fun. That there is room in the car for only three of us doesn't faze me at all. Whirling happily, showing off my biscuit-polished patent-leather shoes and lavender socks, tossing my head in a way that makes my ribbons bounce, I stand, hands on hips, before my father.

ALICE: *(With assurance)* Take me, Daddy. I'm the prettiest!

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INTRODUCTION

The Prettiest . . . What does that mean? Physical features? Big eyes, glossy hair, high cheek bones? Rarely do you hear someone defining beauty as generosity, courage, kindness, and sense of humor." At the age of two, Alice Walker, knew that physical beauty was definitely a selling-point. And she reveled in the role of being the "prettiest." But how do you cope when a sudden accident renders you disfigured and you aren't pretty anymore? Can you find the beauty within? Beauty: When the Other Dancer is the Self by Alice Walker.

Later, it does not surprise me to find myself sharing the back seat with the other lucky ones. At home that night I tell the unlucky ones all I can remember about the merry-go-round, the man who eats live chickens, and the teddy bears, until they say: that's enough, baby Alice. Shut up now, and go to sleep.

It is Easter Sunday, 1950. I am six years old and have learned one of the longest Easter speeches to be heard that day. When I rise to give my speech I do so on a great wave of love and pride and expectation. People in

the church stop rustling. They seem to hold their breath. I can tell they admire my dress, but it is my spirit, bordering on sassiness, they secretly applaud. "That girl's a little mess," they whisper to each other, pleased. Naturally I say my speech without stammer or pause, unlike those who stutter, stammer, or, worst of all, forget. This is before the word "beautiful" exists in people's vocabulary, but "Oh, isn't she the cutest thing!" frequently floats my way.

It was great fun being cute. But then, one day, it ended.

I am eight years old and a tomboy. I have a cowboy hat, cowboy hoots, checkered shirt and pants, all red. My playmates are my brothers, two and four years older than I. We chase each other for hours rustling cattle, being outlaws, delivering damsels from distress. Then my parents decide to buy my brothers guns. These are not "real" guns. They shoot BBs. Because I am a girl, I do not get a gun. Instantly I am relegated to the position of Indian.

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One day while I am standing on top of our makeshift "garage" --pieces of tin nailed across some poles-- holding my bow and arrow and looking out toward the fields, I feel an incredible blow in my right eye. I look down just in time to see my brother lower his gun.

BROTHER: If you tell, we will get a whipping. You don't want that to happen, do you? Here is a piece of wire, say you stepped on one end of it and the other flew up and hit you.

Confronted by our parents we stick to the lie agreed upon. First there is intense fever, Then there are chills: A week after the "accident" they take me to see a doctor.

DOCTOR: *(Looking into the damaged eye and shaking his head)* Why did you wait so long to come? Eyes are sympathetic. If one is blind, the other will likely become blind too.

This comment of the doctor's terrifies me. But it is really how I look that bothers me most. Where the BB

pellet struck there is a glob of whitish scar tissue, a hideous cataract, on my eye. Now when I stare at people--a favorite pastime, up to now--they will stare back. Not at the "cute" little girl, but at her scar. For six years I do not stare at anyone, because I do not raise my head.

I am eight, and, for the first time, doing poorly in school, where I have been something of a whiz since I was four.

I am twelve. I abuse my eye. I rant and rave at it, in front of the mirror. I plead with it to clear up before morning. I tell it I hate and despise it. I do not pray for sight. I pray for beauty.

I am fourteen and baby-sitting for my brother Bill, who lives in Boston. He is my favorite. Understanding my feelings of shame and ugliness he and his wife take me to a local hospital, where the "glob" is removed. There is still a small bluish crater where the scar tissue was, but the ugly white stuff is gone. Almost immediately I

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become a different person from the girl who does not raise her head. Or so I think.

Now that I've raised my head I win the boyfriend of my dreams. Now that I've raised my head I have plenty of friends. Now that I've raised my head classwork comes from my lips as faultlessly as Easter speeches did, and I leave high school as valedictorian, most popular student, and queen, hardly believing my luck.

Ironically, the girl who was voted most beautiful in our class (and was) was later shot twice through the chest by a male companion, using a "real" gun, while she was pregnant. But that's another story in itself. Or is it?

It is now thirty years since the "accident." [And] I remember:

I am talking to my brother Jimmy, asking if he remembers anything unusual about the day I was shot. He does not know I consider that day the last time my father, with his sweet home remedy of cool lily leaves,

chose me, and that I suffered and raged inside because of this.

JIMMY: Well, all I remember is standing by the side of the highway with Daddy, trying to flag down a car. A white man stopped, but when Daddy said he needed somebody to take his little girl to the doctor, he drove off.

I remember:

[Being] in the desert for the first time. I am so overwhelmed by its beauty, I confront for the first time, consciously, the meaning of the doctor's words years ago: "Eyes are sympathetic. If one is blind, the other will likely become blind too." I realize I have dashed about the world madly, looking at this, looking at that, storing up images against the fading of the light. But I might have missed seeing the desert! The shock of that possibility--and gratitude for over twenty-five years of sight--sends me literally to my knees.

But mostly, I remember this:

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I am twenty-seven, and my baby daughter is almost three. Since the birth I have worried about her discovery that her mother's eyes are different from other people's. Will she be embarrassed? I think. What will she say? Every day she watches a television program called Big Blue Marble. It begins with a picture of the earth as it appears from the moon. It is bluish, a little battered-looking, but full of light, with whitish clouds swirling around it. One day when I am putting Rebecca down for her nap, she suddenly focuses on my eye. Something inside me cringes, gets ready to try to protect myself. All children are cruel about physical differences, I know from experience. I assume Rebecca will be the same.

But no-o-o-o. She studies my face. She even holds my face maternally between her dimpled little hands. Then, looking every bit as serious and lawyerlike as her father, she says gently, but with great interest: "Mommy, where did you get that world in your eye?"

For the most part, the pain left then. Crying and laughing I ran to the bathroom, while Rebecca mumbled and sang herself to sleep. Yes indeed, I realized, looking into the mirror. There was a world in my eye. And I saw that it was possible to love it: that in fact, for all it had taught me of shame and anger and inner vision, I did love it. Even to see it drifting out of orbit in boredom, or rolling up out of fatigue, not to mention floating back at attention in excitement, deeply suitable to my personality, and even characteristic of me.

That night I dream I am dancing. As I dance, whirling and joyous, happier than I've ever been in my life, another bright-faced dancer joins me. The other dancer has obviously come through all right, as I have done. She is beautiful, whole, and free . . . And she is also me.

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AWARD HISTORY

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